

"But" as the signal that the constraint may be coming

This paper represents a framework for decision-making that helps spot when a term "but" is used to weaken the original claim.

Organizations frequently state principles, priorities, or values and then immediately introduce constraints that may materially limit those principles. Because the second clause often contains the operational constraint, analysts can miss an important trade-off if they focus only on the headline claim.

When a stated priority is followed by a constraint introduced with "but," the second clause should be treated as a signal to investigate whether the stated priority can actually be achieved under the stated conditions.

The term "but" works as a discourse marker:

- The second clause overweights the first one (does it provide evidence against the first or does it merely add context?)
- It may signal that the second clause deserves more weight (exposing the real need of the speaker)

"But" is a signal, not a verdict. By that we mean:

STOP → something important may be coming → investigate the relationship between A and B.	Not: STOP → B is the real priority.
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So, if a CEO says, "*innovation is our highest priority, but every change needs nine levels of approval.*" Our framework would flag that as evidence against the claim that innovation is the priority. Here is a way to decompose it:

Stated priority: Innovation.

Operational constraint: Nine levels of approval.

Potential conflict: Extensive approval requirements may reduce the organization's ability to experiment quickly.

Analytical question: What level of speed and experimentation is actually expected?

Classification

Classification	Structural Pattern	Operational Meaning	Action Required
Additive (Compatible) Qualification	[A], but [B] where B does not constrain A.	Contextual refinement. Both statements co-exist cleanly. A + B coexist	Accept as reality constraint. No conflict.
Operational Override¹	[A], but [B] where B materially constrains the achievement of A.	A stated priority is subject to a constraint that may require a trade-off. A + B create a potential trade-off.	Identify the constraint, determine whether A and B can coexist, and make the trade-off explicit. Investigation needed. Potential conflict.
Preemptive Disclaimer	"I'm not [X], but [Y]" where Y demonstrates X.	Social/Rhetorical shield to preempt criticism. A explicitly denies X while B provides evidence for X.	Surface the contradiction directly. Clear conflict.

When "but" just introduces a compatible qualification, then it's not a fallacy. For example, *"I'm not angry but disappointed."* Or *"We want a successful migration, but authors will need training."* Both can be true.

Second, when "but" introduces a potential conflicting statement. Like someone saying, *"Quality is our top priority, but we don't have time to review 5,000 pages."* The value of the stated priority (quality) is in question because of the operational constraint (no time).

And then third, there's the rhetorical use where "but" is used as a disclaimer or direct contradiction, like *I'm not sexist, but...* and then follows with something that actually reveals that prejudice. Another example: *"I'm not dishonest, but I lied to get the job."*

¹ Business conversations will overwhelmingly fall into the Operational override category

So, the fallacy isn't the word *but* itself. It's the pattern where a disclaimer is used to preemptively deny something that the following words actually support. And that structure could apply in business talk too, like "*We're customer-centric, but we never talk to customers*". That signals tension worth examining.

How to identify the problem

The interesting thing isn't actually the word *but*. It's the relationship between:

Declared priority* → *operational constraint

The first clause tells you what the organization says it wants

The second tells you what reality may prevent it from doing

"But" can signal a gap between what organizations say they value and what their operational constraints allow them to optimize.

Now let's see how to actually identify the problem:

For each "but" statement, identify the principle before "but". Then identify the constraint or exception after "but". And then ask, does the second clause undermine a necessary condition of the first? If yes, it's a conflict to surface, not accept.

A good example for the case where the second weakens the first like when someone says *security is our highest priority, but we don't have time for security testing*. The second part undercuts the claim.

The second part reveals an operational constraint. If there is no time for testing, the organization must decide whether to reduce the testing scope, extend the deadline, increase resources, or accept greater risk. We are not interpreting their intention. We're forcing the underlying decision into the open.

Let's compare this to some correct examples:

- *We want a successful AEM migration, but we know content authors will need training*. That second line reinforces the goal.
- *Customer satisfaction is our priority, but we'll spend extra time validating the migrated content*. That second part strengthens the first.

If the claim after “but” lowers or even negates the value of the principle stated in the same sentence, it means that the speaker is conflicting their own principle. And it’s a problem we have to address.

“But” doesn't automatically mean the claim is false. It often just introduces tension or a competing thought that makes listeners question the initial claim. What's more compelling as a principle is not to declare everything after "but" as negation, but to recognize it as a signal of competing considerations. The deeper principle is teaching people to hear trade-offs clearly.

More examples:

"Our employees are our greatest asset, but we have to reduce the training budget."

→ Ask what trade-off justifies that.

"We trust our teams, but every decision must be approved by management."

→ That flags a tension between trust and control.

"We're committed to innovation but can't afford to take risks"

→ Surfaces an un-expectable risk tolerance. If you can’t take risk, claiming that you are open for innovation doesn’t really sound convincing. Separate the statement from its impact. If "no risks" means no experimentation, then yeah, it effectively undermines innovation. In that case, the useful move is to ask what level of risk is actually acceptable. That reframes it from contradiction to workable trade-off.

Even in personal talk, it appears. *"I trust you, but I need to check your phone."* Each case helps tease out how the second clause changes the first. In professional circumstances we have to be able to capture the second clause as the real constraint and then guide a conversation to resolve it.

Testing claims with follow up questions

One way to handle this problem is by testing statements by questioning the details and their consequences. Let's imagine that the business stakeholder says something like *"We want to be as agile as we can, but security standards are a must have"*. When a claim is strong, but then the follow up undermines it, that's the tell. You can test it by asking, *"If we prioritize speed, what happens to security standards?"* if that's unclear, you're likely looking at a rhetorical move not a real plan.

So, when you spot a mismatch like lofty language, but opposite actions, that's your cue to press gently, ask for concrete examples or trade-offs. It turns a fuzzy statement into something testable.

Buzzwords such as "agile" and "innovation" can obscure the operational constraints that determine how those principles are actually implemented. Rather than debating the terminology, the analyst can ask what the organization is willing to change, fund, accelerate, or accept risk for.

Another example, if stakeholders say *"Content quality is top priority, but we don't have time to review all 5,000 pages,"* we can steer the conversation towards making decisions.

The stakeholders have effectively given us two requirements:

- R1: High content quality.
- R2: Limited time.

Now its time to ask a question that will uncover the real need of the client:

- What does "high quality" mean under this constraint?

The objective is not to debate the wording. The objective is to turn rhetorical tension into a concrete decision. Then we can get in the real details by asking further questions like:

Which pages are high risk? What constitutes acceptable quality? What's the minimum acceptable quality review? Which outcomes matter more, speed or perfection? Can we use sampling?	Which content must receive 100% review? Which content can receive automated validation? What is the deadline? What happens if quality and schedule cannot both be maximized?
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Conclusion: *But* from a signal to operational decision

In practice, using “but” is less like a formal contradiction and more like a pragmatic override. Our job isn’t to uncover the logical fallacy in the speaker’s statement, but rather to understand what the speaker actually wanted to say.

The goal of the paper ultimately isn't about discovering what someone secretly prioritizes. It's about turning ambiguous statements into explicit decisions. So the problem has to be addressed in the following way:

1. **Identify a conflict** - Separate the stated objective from the constraint that follows it.
2. **Ask follow up questions** - Determine whether the two can coexist and what consequences the constraint creates.
3. **Confirm the interpretation** - Make the stakeholder confirm that the analyst has correctly understood the requirement and its constraints.
4. **Make the trade-off explicit** - If the two objectives cannot both be fully achieved, establish which outcome, level of quality, risk, or constraint the organization is willing to accept.

Imagine:

"Content quality is our top priority, but we don't have time to review 5,000 pages."

We can:

1. Identify: Quality vs. time.
2. Question: What does "high quality" mean? Which pages matter most?
3. Confirm: "So, if I understand correctly, we're prioritizing critical content for manual review while using automated validation for the remainder?"
4. Decide: Everyone explicitly accepts that trade-off.